

Board 1

North Deals
None Vul

♠ K 9 6 2
♥ J 9 5
♦ Q J 6 2
♣ 10 7

♠ 8 7 3
♥ A K 2
♦ K 8 3
♣ A J 5 2

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ A J 4
♥ Q 10 7 3
♦ 10 9 4
♣ 9 4 3

♠ Q 10 5
♥ 8 6 4
♦ A 7 5
♣ K Q 8 6

<i>West</i>	<i>North</i>	<i>East</i>	<i>South</i>
	1NT	Pass	3NT

All Pass

3NT by North

Lead: ♥3

The second is more likely. Suppose West wins the ♠K.

West returns a ♥.

East follows and dummy plays the ♥6.

East plays the ♠J.

The ♠Q wins the trick. If the ♠Q wins, take your 9 tricks and run.

Although this doesn't look like a normal A Q finesse it really is about the same.

Whenever the ♠A and ♠K are in different hands, the only thing that matters is the location of the ♠J.

So it is basically a 50% chance.

North is to play 3NT. East leads the ♥3, dummy plays the ♥4 and West the ♥J.

Winners: ♠=0 ♥=2 ♦=2 ♣=4 Total = 8

First things first. Win the first ♥, do not hold up. East's ♥3 indicates he has led a 4-card suit so a hold-up wouldn't help you. And if you did hold up they might pocket their ♥ trick and switch to ♦s, a suit you are no better off in.

You need to get one more winner and it will have to be a ♠ winner.

East plays low.

You could lead toward the ♠Q, winning a trick if East holds BOTH the ♠A and ♠K. Or you could finesse the ♠10, gaining a trick if East holds the ♠J.

Board 2

South Deals

None Vul

♠ 7
 ♥ Q 10 8 3
 ♦ K J 9 2
 ♣ 9 8 4 2

♠ Q 9 6 2

♥ A 6 5

♦ 8 6 4

♣ 6 5 3

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ K 5 4 3

♥ J 9 7 2

♦ A 10 7

♣ 10 7

♠ A J 10 8

♥ K 4

♦ Q 5 3

♣ A K Q J

West	North	East	South
			2NT
Pass	3♣	Pass	3♠
Pass	4♠		
All Pass			
4♠ by South			
Lead: ♦ 2			

South is to play 4♠. West leads the ♦ 2. The defenders win 3 ♦ tricks, then play a ♣.

Losers: ♠ = 0 or 1 ♥ = 0 ♦ = 3 ♣ = 0 Total = 3 or 4

Since you have already lost 3 ♦ tricks you cannot also lose a ♠ trick. That means East will have to have the ♠K and it also means that you will have to be careful with your finessing.

You are in your hand, having won the ♣ switch.

West plays low.

Over to dummy's ♥ A.

You lead the ♠Q from dummy and East plays low.

The ♠Q from dummy, and the ♠J (or 10) from your hand when East plays low.

The ♠Q held the trick so you are still in dummy.

East doesn't cover.

The ♠9, playing your ♠8 under it. West shows out on this trick and you are glad you played so carefully. Play one more ♠, finessing East's ♠K again, then play your ♠A and the rest of your winners.

If you had played the ♠Q and carelessly followed with the ♠8 on your first finesse you would have gone down. You would have had to win the second finesse in your hand and would have no dummy entry to let you take the third finesse.

True, the chances of East holding 4 ♠s to the King are pretty small, but it costs you nothing to protect yourself against that holding.

And the rewards are great.

Board 3

North Deals

E-W Vul

♠ 9 6 5 2
 ♥ A 9 6 2
 ♦ 10 8 3
 ♣ K 3

♠ A K 3

♥ K 4

♦ A K 6 5

♣ J 7 6 2

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ J 8 4

♥ Q J 8 7 3

♦ J 9 4

♣ 9 4

♠ Q 10 7

♥ 10 5

♦ Q 7 2

♣ A Q 10 8 5

West

North

East

South

1♦

Pass

2♣

Pass

3NT

All Pass

3NT by North

Lead: ♥7

North is to play 3NT. East leads the ♥7. West takes the ♥A and returns the ♥2.

Winners: ♠=3 ♥=1 ♦=3 ♣=1 Total = 8

You need one more winner and ♣s is your best suit. If the ♣K is in East's hand you can finesse it for 12 tricks. But if the ♣K is in West's hand you will lose that trick and at least 4 ♥s.

Before you put all your eggs in the ♣ finesse basket there is one thing you should do first.

East plays low.

You test the ♦ suit: a small one to dummy's ♦Q, then the ♦K and ♦A.

Both defenders followed three times, so your last ♦ is a winner.

You cash it.

Now you have a problem. You have won 5 tricks so far and you have 4 more winners ready to take. So you can take your 9 tricks and run, or you can finesse the ♣ trying for 3 overtricks.

It's your decision, but </br></br>

At Rubber Bridge or Team play it would probably be foolish to risk your contract for the sake of three overtricks.

But at Match Point Pairs the reward would be much greater, a probable very high board. Of course with this layout it might have gotten you a bottom board.

Board 4

South Deals

None Vul

♠ 10 8 5 2
 ♥ Q J 9 4 3
 ♦ Q 4
 ♣ J 9

♠ A 6 3
 ♥ 7 5 2
 ♦ A 7 5 3
 ♣ 10 5 4

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ K 9
 ♥ 10 8 6
 ♦ K J 9
 ♣ 8 7 6 3 2

♠ Q J 7 4
 ♥ A K
 ♦ 10 8 6 2
 ♣ A K Q

West	North	East	South
			1 ♦
Pass	2 ♦	Pass	3NT
All Pass			
3NT by South			
Lead: ♥ Q			

South is to play 3NT. West leads the ♥ Q, dummy plays the ♥ 2 and East the ♥ 6.

Winners: ♠=1 ♥=2 ♦=1 ♣=3 Total = 7

You need two more winners and ♦ s is your longest combined suit. But you can only establish one extra winner in ♦ s, and before you could even do that the defenders would have taken a bunch of ♥ tricks.

So you must turn to the ♠ s for the extra two winners.

You won the first ♥ .

West plays low.

Which ♠ was right? If you play the ♠ Q you will go down, even if West has the ♠ K. He would cover and you would be held to just 2 ♠ tricks.

The only way to get 3 tricks from this holding is to play East for the ♠ K. So play a ♠ to dummy's ♠ A and then a small ♠ back toward your ♠ Q J.

East puts on the ♠ K.

You are home-free.

You were a little lucky that East's ♠ K fell on the second round.

If it had not dropped you would just have played a third round of ♠ s, hoping for a 3-3 split in the suit.

You could also have gotten 3 ♠ winners with this distribution.

Board 5

South Deals

N-S Vul

♠ K J 8 4
 ♥ 10 9 4 2
 ♦ Q J 10 5
 ♣ 5

♠ Q 3

♥ K Q 5

♦ K 9 4 2

♣ Q J 7 4



♠ 10 9 6 2

♥ 8 7 6

♦ 7 3

♣ A K 8 2

♠ A 7 5

♥ A J 3

♦ A 8 6

♣ 10 9 6 3

West	North	East	South
			1 ♣
Pass	2NT	Pass	3NT
All Pass			
3NT by North			
Lead: ♣ A			

North is to play 3NT. East leads the ♣A, then ♣K, ♣2. West follows once, then discards a ♠ and a ♥.

East leads the ♣A, then ♣K, ♣2. West follows once, then discards a ♠ and a ♥.

Winners: ♠=1 ♥=3 ♦=2 ♣=2 Total = 8

There are two possibilities for getting an extra winner. If the ♦s are splitting 3-3 you could play ♦A, ♦K and another ♦ and establish the thirteenth ♦ as a winner. Or you could play West for the ♠K and lead toward your ♠Q.

The chance of West holding the ♠K is a little greater than 50%. (it is higher than the usual 50% because we know he started with only one ♣, giving him more spaces for other cards).

The chance of ♦s splitting 3-3 is about 40%.

East plays low.

You enter dummy with a ♥.

West plays low.

A small ♠ toward your ♠Q.

Did it work?

You might have thought of another possibility; duck a ♦, then play ♦A and ♦K to see if the ♦s split before you try leading toward the ♠Q.

The problem is that you might run into this very distribution. You would establish a ♦ for West and when you played a ♠ from dummy West would jump up with the ♠K and cash his winning ♦ for down 1.

Board 6

West Deals

None Vul

♠ K J 3

♥ Q 7 3

♦ K Q J 9 5

♣ 8 4

♠ 9 4 2

♥ A 8 5

♦ 7 6 3

♣ A K 6 5

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ 10 8 7 6

♥ 10 6 4 2

♦ 8 2

♣ 10 7 3

♠ A Q 5

♥ K J 9

♦ A 10 4

♣ Q J 9 2

West

1 ♦

Pass

All Pass

3NT by South

Lead: ♦ K

North

Pass

3NT

East

Pass

South

1NT

and East the ♦ 8.

West continues with the ♦ J; dummy plays the ♦ 7 and East discards a ♠.

You held up the ♦ A until the third round to confirm that East has only 2. He does.

You cash four rounds of ♣s, ending in your hand.

West covers with the ♥ Q.

Now play the ♥ J. If West doesn't cover, you will let it ride for your ninth trick. But West does cover so you must take dummy's ♥ A.

East plays low.

A small ♥ from dummy, finessing the ♥ 9, hoping East has the ♥ 10. This is the Backward Finesse.

The Backward Finesse is a pretty rare play. It is against the odds so you only try it when you are absolutely certain that a normal finesse is doomed to fail.

Like this time.

By the way. Those of you with great short-term memories might think they have seen this hand before. Well, you ALMOST have. Deal 8 has an almost identical layout but a much simpler theme. Check it out.

South is to play 3NT. West leads the ♦ K, dummy plays the ♦ 3 and East the ♦ 2.

Winners: ♠=1 ♥=2 ♦=1 ♣=4 Total = 8

You only need one more winner. If East has the ♠ K or the ♥ Q a simple finesse will give you the trick.

There are two problems though. The first one is that if West gets in he may take too many ♦ tricks. But the bigger problem is that East cannot possibly have either of those two high cards. You and dummy together hold 28 HCP and West must surely hold the other 12 since he opened the bidding. Neither simple finesse will work so you must try what is called a Backward Finesse.

Then play four rounds of ♣s ending in your hand.

West continues with the ♦ Q; dummy plays the ♦ 6